

SALIENT FEATURES OF THE INDIAN CONSTITUTION

THE CONSTITUTION AS A – WRITTEN DETAIL AND THREE – FEDERAL DESIGN: DIVIDED POWER – RESPONSIBLE EXECUTIVE UNDER CONSTITUTIONAL – RIGHTS, DIRECTIVE PRINCIPLES AND – DEMOCRATIC PARTICIPATION AND ACCOUNTABILITY

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure, the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • active generation g15 repaired in place for answer-line and visual-boundary quality • all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 THE CONSTITUTION AS A LAYERED OPERATING SYSTEM

THE CONSTITUTION AS A LAYERED OPERATING SYSTEM INDIAN CONSTITUTION WRITTEN, DETAILED, SUPREME, PARTLY RIGID AND PARTLY FLEXIBLE FEDERAL DISTRIBUTION WITH A STRONG AND COORDINATING UNION PARLIAMENTARY RESPONSIBILITY AND BICAMERAL LEGISLATION JUDICIAL REVIEW, RULE OF LAW AND BASIC-STRUCTURE CONTROL RIGHTS, DPSPS, DUTIES, JUSTICE, DIGNITY AND FRATERNITY ADULT FRANCHISE, ELECTIONS AND LOCAL SELF-GOVERNMENT

INDIAN CONSTITUTION

FORM: written, detailed, supreme, partly rigid and partly flexible		→	POWER: federal distribution with a strong and coordinating Union		→	GOVERNMENT: parliamentary responsibility and bicameral legislation	
CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE		POWER / PROCEDURE		CHECK / LIMIT		FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT	
• INDIAN CONSTITUTION • FORM: written, detailed, supreme, partly rigid and partly flexible • POWER: federal distribution with a strong and coordinating Union		• GOVERNMENT: parliamentary responsibility and bicameral legislation • LIMIT: judicial review, rule of law and basic-structure control • PURPOSE: rights, DPSPs, duties, justice, dignity and fraternity		• PARTICIPATION: adult franchise, elections and local self-government • INTEGRATION: single citizenship, integrated judiciary, All-India Services • PLURALISM: language, asymmetry, minorities and special arrangements		• CRISIS MODE: Emergency powers under constitutional conditions • A salient feature explains how several provisions work together.	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A salient constitutional feature matters through its relationship with other features, as federal distribution, parliamentary responsibility, rights and review jointly structure limited government.							

01

STAGE 01 WRITTEN DETAIL AND THREE AMENDMENT TRACKS

WRITTEN DETAIL AND THREE AMENDMENT TRACKS WHY DETAILED? FEDERAL DISTRIBUTION + DIVERSITY + ADMINISTRATIVE CONTINUITY + RIGHTS CHANGE ROUTES SIMPLE MAJORITY OUTSIDE ARTICLE 368 STATE REORGANISATION AND SPECIFIED INSTITUTIONAL ADJUSTMENTS ARTICLE 368 SPECIAL MAJORITY TOTAL-MEMBERSHIP MAJORITY + TWO-THIRDS PRESENT SPECIAL MAJORITY + HALF OF STATE LEGISLATURES FEDERAL PROVISIONS

WHY DETAILED?

federal distribution + diversity + administrative continuity + rights + institutions		→	CHANGE ROUTES	→	SIMPLE MAJORITY OUTSIDE ARTICLE 368	
CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE • WHY DETAILED? • federal distribution + diversity + administrative continuity + rights + institutions • CHANGE ROUTES		POWER / PROCEDURE • SIMPLE MAJORITY OUTSIDE ARTICLE 368 • State reorganisation and specified institutional adjustments • ARTICLE 368 SPECIAL MAJORITY total-membership majority + two-thirds present and voting		CHECK / LIMIT • SPECIAL MAJORITY + HALF OF STATE LEGISLATURES federal provisions and listed Union-State institutions • OUTER LIMIT • Article 368 power → amendment permitted		FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT • destruction of basic structure prohibited • Flexibility enables adaptation; rigidity protects constitutional identity.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: India's written detail is an accommodation device: it constitutionalises diversity and administration, while remaining dependent on conventions, interpretation and implementation.						

02

STAGE 02 FEDERAL DESIGN: DIVIDED POWER, INTEGRATED NATION

FEDERAL DESIGN DIVIDED POWER, INTEGRATED NATION FEDERAL CORE WRITTEN SUPREMACY + TWO LEVELS + DIVIDED CENTRALISING FEATURES UNION-WEIGHTED FIELDS AND RESIDUARY POWER SINGLE CITIZENSHIP, INTEGRATED JUDICIARY EMERGENCY CONVERSION OF OPERATING BALANCE COOPERATIVE FEATURES INTER-STATE COUNCIL

FEDERAL CORE written supremacy + two levels + divided competence + independent adjudication

CENTRALISING FEATURES		→ Union-weighted fields and residuary power single citizenship, integrated judiciary and All-India Services	→ Emergency conversion of operating balance
CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
• FEDERAL CORE written supremacy + two levels + divided competence + independent adjudication • CENTRALISING FEATURES • Union-weighted fields and residuary power single citizenship, integrated judiciary and All-India Services	• Emergency conversion of operating balance • COOPERATIVE FEATURES • Inter-State Council	• Finance Commission • GST Council grants, shared schemes and administrative coordination • ASYMMETRIC FEATURES different arrangements for different States and regions language and tribal-area accommodation	• VERDICT: federal with strong integrative mechanisms, not unitary with decoration.
MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: federal with strong integrative mechanisms, not unitary with decoration.			
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: indian federalism distributes power to accommodate diversity, but retains centralising, cooperative and asymmetric devices so the Union can coordinate without erasing the States.			

03

STAGE 03 RESPONSIBLE EXECUTIVE UNDER CONSTITUTIONAL CHECKS

RESPONSIBLE EXECUTIVE UNDER CONSTITUTIONAL CHECKS LOK SABHA COUNCIL OF MINISTERS COLLECTIVE RESPONSIBILITY CONFIDENCE REQUIREMENT QUESTIONS, COMMITTEES FORMAL EXECUTIVE REAL POLITICAL EXECUTIVE PRIME MINISTER-LED COUNCIL OF MINISTERS

LEGISLATURE MAKES LAW <– EXECUTIVE INITIATES AND ADMINISTERS JUDICIARY REVIEWS LEGALITY <– LEGISLATURE MAY VALIDLY AMEND OR

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE - PEOPLE – LOK SABHA – COUNCIL OF MINISTERS collective responsibility confidence requirement questions, committees and financial control - FORMAL EXECUTIVE: President	POWER / PROCEDURE - REAL POLITICAL EXECUTIVE: Prime Minister-led Council of Ministers - Legislature makes law <– Executive initiates and administers	CHECK / LIMIT - Judiciary reviews legality <– Legislature may validly amend or reenact - President acts constitutionally <– limited discretion remains reviewable	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT - NO WATERTIGHT SEPARATION functional overlap + institutional restraint + constitutional supremacy - PEOPLE – LOK SABHA – COUNCIL OF MINISTERS collective responsibility confidence requirement questions, committees and financial control
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE – WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Parliamentary government makes the executive continuously responsible to the elected lower House, although disciplined majorities can turn legislative confidence into executive dominance.			

04

STAGE 04 RIGHTS, DIRECTIVE PRINCIPLES AND DUTIES: THE NORMATIVE TRIANGLE

RIGHTS, DIRECTIVE PRINCIPLES AND DUTIES THE NORMATIVE TRIANGLE FUNDAMENTAL RIGHTS SHIELD LIBERTY, EQUALITY AND DIGNITY; JUDICIALLY ENFORCEABLE DIRECTIVE PRINCIPLES DIRECT WELFARE, REDISTRIBUTION AND TRANSFORMATION; NON-JUSTICIABLE FUNDAMENTAL DUTIES STATE CIVIC EXPECTATIONS; NOT DIRECTLY ENFORCEABLE AS CONSTITUTIONAL MORALITY POWER PURSUES PUBLIC PURPOSES THROUGH LAWFUL AND MINERVA MILLS (1980) HARMONY BETWEEN PARTS III AND IV IS PART OF

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE - FUNDAMENTAL RIGHTS shield liberty, equality and dignity; judicially enforceable - DIRECTIVE PRINCIPLES direct welfare, redistribution and transformation; non-justiciable	POWER / PROCEDURE - FUNDAMENTAL DUTIES state civic expectations; not directly enforceable as rights - CONSTITUTIONAL MORALITY power pursues public purposes through lawful and rights-respecting means	CHECK / LIMIT - MINERVA MILLS (1980) - Harmony between Parts III and IV is part of basic structure.	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT - Rights are not absolute. DPSPs are not irrelevant; Duties do not erase rights. - FUNDAMENTAL RIGHTS shield liberty, equality and dignity; judicially enforceable
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE – WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Fundamental Rights restrain power, Directive Principles direct social transformation and Fundamental Duties express civic responsibility; constitutional balance requires harmony without erasing their different legal status.			

05

STAGE 05 DEMOCRATIC PARTICIPATION AND ACCOUNTABILITY ECOSYSTEM

DEMOCRATIC PARTICIPATION AND ACCOUNTABILITY ECOSYSTEM CITIZEN ADULT FRANCHISE REPRESENTATIVE GOVERNMENT UNION/STATE ELECTIONS ELECTION COMMISSION SUPERVISION LOCAL DEMOCRACY PARTS IX AND IXA ACCOUNTABILITY CHAIN LEGISLATURES POLITICAL AND FINANCIAL SCRUTINY

CITIZEN adult franchise – representative government

Union/State elections → Election Commission supervision local democracy → Parts IX and IXA		→ ACCOUNTABILITY CHAIN legislatures → political and financial scrutiny	→ CAG → audit evidence
CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE • CITIZEN adult franchise → representative government • Union/State elections → Election Commission supervision local democracy → Parts IX and IXA	POWER / PROCEDURE • ACCOUNTABILITY CHAIN legislatures → political and financial scrutiny • CAG → audit evidence	CHECK / LIMIT • Finance Commission → fiscal distribution • UPSC / State PSCs → recruitment safeguards courts → legality and rights review	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT • SUBSTANTIVE DEMOCRACY vote + local participation + affirmative action + social justice • Independence requires secure tenure, resources, fair appointments and compliance.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Universal adult franchise established equal political membership from the Constitution's commencement, while representative institutions and bicameralism channel that equality into government.			

06

STAGE 06 NORMAL MODE, EMERGENCY MODE AND RESTORATION

NORMAL MODE, EMERGENCY MODE AND RESTORATION NORMAL MODE FEDERAL DISTRIBUTION + RESPONSIBLE GOVERNMENTS + ORDINARY ART 352 NATIONAL EMERGENCY UNION POWER EXPANDS; ARTICLES 358/359 FOLLOW EXACT CONDITIONS ART 356 FAILURE OF CONSTITUTIONAL MACHINERY IN A STATE SPECIFIED STATE ART 360

NORMAL MODE federal distribution + responsible governments + ordinary rights enforcement	ART 352: national Emergency	Union power expands; Articles 358/359 follow exact conditions	ART 356: failure of constitutional machinery in a State specified State functions assumed; legislative control	ART 360: financial Emergency financial directions may alter ordinary fiscal autonomy
CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE - NORMAL MODE federal distribution + responsible governments + ordinary rights enforcement - ART 352: national Emergency	POWER / PROCEDURE - Union power expands; Articles 358/359 follow exact conditions - ART 356: failure of constitutional machinery in a State specified State functions assumed; legislative control applies	CHECK / LIMIT - ART 360: financial Emergency financial directions may alter ordinary fiscal autonomy - UPSC / State PSCs – recruitment safeguards courts – legality and rights review	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT - RESTORATION OF NORMAL CONSTITUTIONAL BALANCE - Emergency is a constitutional mode, not an unreviewable constitutional suspension.	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE – WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Emergency provisions permit temporary constitutional centralisation for crisis management, but they do not authorise permanent unitary rule or extra-constitutional government.				

07

STAGE 07 FEATURE TENSIONS: STRENGTH ON ONE AXIS, RISK ON ANOTHER

FEATURE TENSIONS STRENGTH ON ONE AXIS, RISK ON ANOTHER FEATURE CONSTITUTIONAL GAIN INTERNAL RISK STRONG UNION INTEGRITY AND EMERGENCY POWERS CRISIS CAPACITY NORMALISED EXCEPTION ASYMMETRY PLURAL ACCOMMODATION CONSTITUTIONAL MORALITY TURNS INSTITUTIONAL POWER INTO RESTRAINED TRUSTEESHIP.

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
FEATURE CONSTITUTIONAL GAIN INTERNAL RISK strong Union integrity and coordination central overreach parliamentary executive daily accountability executive dominance	blend durability plus adaptation strategic change	Constitutional morality turns institutional power into restrained trusteeship.	Judicial review rights and limited power counter-majoritarian concern length and detail certainty and inclusion complexity and legalism amendment
Judicial review rights and limited power counter-majoritarian concern length and detail certainty and inclusion complexity and legalism amendment	Emergency powers crisis capacity normalised exception asymmetry plural accommodation unequal-bargain criticism independent bodies specialised accountability appointment dependence	FEATURE CONSTITUTIONAL GAIN INTERNAL RISK strong Union integrity and coordination central overreach parliamentary executive daily accountability executive dominance	blend durability plus adaptation strategic change
CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE	POWER / PROCEDURE	CHECK / LIMIT	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT
FEATURE CONSTITUTIONAL GAIN INTERNAL RISK strong Union integrity and coordination central overreach parliamentary executive daily accountability executive dominance	blend durability plus adaptation strategic change	Constitutional morality turns institutional power into restrained trusteeship.	Judicial review rights and limited power counter-majoritarian concern length and detail certainty and inclusion complexity and legalism amendment
Judicial review rights and limited power counter-majoritarian concern length and detail certainty and inclusion complexity and legalism amendment	Emergency powers crisis capacity normalised exception asymmetry plural accommodation unequal-bargain criticism independent bodies specialised accountability appointment dependence	FEATURE CONSTITUTIONAL GAIN INTERNAL RISK strong Union integrity and coordination central overreach parliamentary executive daily accountability executive dominance	blend durability plus adaptation strategic change
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE – WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Government of India Act, 1935 contributed institutional and administrative continuity, but the Constitution changed the source and ends of authority through republicanism, universal franchise, rights and accountable government.			

08

STAGE 08 EXACT 10/15-MARK ARCHITECTURE: WHY THE CONSTITUTION IS A BALANCED SYNTHESIS

EXACT 10/15-MARK ARCHITECTURE WHY THE CONSTITUTION IS A BALANCED SYNTHESIS 10 MARKS 150 WORDS 1. DEFINE FEATURE AS AN INTERACTING DESIGN CHOICE, NOT 2. SELECT THREE CLUSTERS POWER, LIMITATION AND SOCIAL PURPOSE. 3. ATTACH ONE PROVISION OR INSTITUTION TO EACH CLUSTER.

10 MARKS / 150 WORDS	1. Define feature as an interacting design choice, not an adjective.	2. Select three clusters: power, limitation and social purpose.	3. Attach one provision or institution to each cluster.	4. Show one tension: strong Union, executive dominance or review.
CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE • 10 MARKS / 150 WORDS • 1. Define feature as an interacting design choice, not an adjective. • 2. Select three clusters: power, limitation and social purpose. • 3. Attach one provision or institution to each cluster.	POWER / PROCEDURE • 4. Show one tension: strong Union, executive dominance or review. • 5. Conclude with balance maintained through accountability. • 15 MARKS / 250 WORDS • 1. Begin with written supremacy and amendment blend.	CHECK / LIMIT • 2. Explain federalism plus centralising, cooperative and asymmetric dimensions. • 3. Link parliamentary responsibility to checks and judicial review. • 4. Integrate rights, DPSPs, duties, franchise and local democracy. • 5. Add independent bodies and Emergency modes.	FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT • 6. Evaluate two design tensions and constitutional morality. • 7. Conclude: synthesis is dynamic; tensions do not disappear.	
MECHANISM / VERDICT — 7. Conclude: synthesis is dynamic; tensions do not disappear.				
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A salient constitutional feature remains qualified by related provisions, so interpretations that convert it into an absolute rule are legally unsound.				

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT – ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT 0. FRAMING THE 17 SALIENT FEATURES SOURCES OF THE CONSTITUTION – FULL TABLE (TABLE 3.4) [FACT – CURRENT LINK] CA UPSC TRAPS MAINS ANGLES HISTORICAL PYQ INTEGRATION (2018-2023)

OPTIONAL DOCTRINE / CASE	ADVANCED LIMIT	COMPARATIVE NUANCE
0. Framing - The 17 Salient Features - Sources of the Constitution – full table (Table 3.4) Prelims gold - Criticism	[FACT – CURRENT LINK] CA / relevance - UPSC Traps - Mains angles - Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)	[FACT – CURRENT LINK] J&K: till 2019 J&K had its own Constitution (Article 370); In Re: Article 370 of the Constitution (2023) upheld the 2019 changes [FACT – CURRENT LINK] Co-operatives (feature 17): Union of India v. Rajendra N. Shah (2021) ruling + creation of the Ministry of - NOT: "Federation" is used in the Constitution – never; Art 1 says "Union of States." - NOT: Concurrent List borrowed from Canada – Australia; strong-Centre federalism – Canada.
OPTIONAL STATUS – This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.		